SHELTER & STAYING WARM

Keeping people warm, dry and out of the weather: at home without power, in a car, or outdoors.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General preparedness information, not a substitute for professional training, local rules, manufacturer instructions or medical care. **Practice skills in safe conditions before you need them, and verify important information with current official sources.**

Most cold-weather deaths in emergencies come from cold exposure and from unsafe heating, not from lack of food. The best shelter is almost always a sturdy building. These skills are for when the building has no heat, or you can't get to one.

1. HOW YOUR BODY LOSES HEAT

HOW	WHAT HAPPENS	FIX
Contact	Cold ground, walls or seats pull heat straight out of you.	Put insulation **under** you: a pad, cardboard, blankets, dry leaves.
Wind	Moving air strips away the warm layer around your body.	Block the wind: windproof outer layer, walls, a tarp, a car.
Wet	Wet clothes lose most of their warmth, and water carries heat away fast.	Stay dry. Change out of wet clothes. Avoid sweating: take a layer off before you work.
Radiation	Your body gives off heat into open, cold space.	Cover your head and neck; use a smaller space; a foil emergency blanket helps.

2. DRESSING FOR COLD: LAYERS

BASE LAYER

Next to the skin. Wool or synthetic, which stay warm when damp. Avoid cotton in cold, wet weather: it holds water.

MIDDLE LAYER

Insulation: fleece, wool sweater, down or synthetic jacket. Add or remove to stay warm without sweating.

OUTER LAYER

Wind- and waterproof shell. Plus a hat, gloves or mittens (warmer than gloves), and dry socks.

3. AT HOME WITHOUT HEAT

- Pick one room to live in: small, on the sunny side, with few windows. Close off the rest of the house.
- Hang blankets over doors and windows; put towels along drafty door bottoms. Open curtains on sunny windows in the day; close them at night.
- Everyone in one room shares body heat. Sleep in layers with a hat, under several blankets, on a pad or mattress, not the bare floor.
- Eat regular meals and drink water. Your body needs fuel to make heat.
- Let faucets drip and open cabinet doors under sinks to help keep pipes from freezing.
- Check on older neighbors and people who live alone.
- If your home gets too cold to be safe, go to a warming center, shelter, or family. Know where they are before the storm.

> ⓘ **NEVER HEAT WITH AN OVEN, GRILL, CAMP STOVE OR GENERATOR.** They make carbon monoxide, which kills without warning. Use fuel-burning space heaters only if they're designed for indoor use, and follow the instructions. Keep anything that can burn 3 feet away from heaters. Have working CO alarms.

4. STRANDED IN A CAR IN WINTER

- **Stay with the car** unless help is close and visible. A car is easier to find than a person.
- Run the engine and heater about **10 minutes each hour**. Open a downwind window a little while it runs.
- Keep the exhaust pipe **clear of snow**: a blocked pipe can fill the car with carbon monoxide.
- Turn on the dome light while the engine runs, and tie something bright to the antenna, so rescuers can see you.
- Move arms and legs to keep blood flowing. Huddle together; use blankets, newspapers, floor mats.
- Take turns sleeping, so someone is always awake. *(TR-09)*

5. OUTDOORS: A BASIC SHELTER

PICK THE SPOT

- Out of the wind, on high, dry, flat ground.
- Not in a dry creek bed or low spot (flash floods, cold air pools at night).
- Not under dead trees or hanging dead branches.
- Not on a ridge top or under a lone tall tree in a thunderstorm.
- Close to water and firewood if you can, but not right beside them.

TARP SHELTERS

- **Lean-to:** tie a cord between two trees, drape one edge of the tarp over it and stake the other edge to the ground, with the low side toward the wind.
- **A-frame:** drape the tarp over the cord and stake both sides down. Better in rain and changing wind.
- Make it small: you have to heat the space with your body.
- Insulate the ground first: pine boughs, leaves, a pad, a pack.

> **HOT WEATHER:** shelter means shade and air. Rest in the shade during the hottest hours, wet your clothes to cool down, and work in early morning and evening. In a heat wave without air conditioning, go to a cooling center. *(TL-05)*

6. WARNING SIGNS: GET THE PERSON WARM NOW

CONDITION	SIGNS	DO THIS
Hypothermia	Shivering, fumbling hands, confusion, slurred speech, drowsiness. Body temperature below 95°F. In babies: bright red, cold skin and very low energy.	Get medical help. Move to warmth; remove wet clothes; warm the center of the body first. Warm drinks only if fully awake.
Frostbite	Numb skin that is white, grayish-yellow, firm or waxy.	Warm (not hot) water or body heat. Don't rub it. Don't walk on frostbitten feet unless you must.

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Winter Weather; Preventing Hypothermia and Frostbite; Avoiding Carbon Monoxide Poisoning. cdc.gov/winter-weather
2. National Weather Service: Winter Safety; Winter Travel. weather.gov/safety/winter
3. FEMA: Ready.gov: Winter Weather; Extreme Heat. ready.gov/winter-weather
4. National Park Service: Hiking Safety. nps.gov

IMPORTANT: Follow manufacturer instructions for any heater. This document reflects the sources above as of November 2026.